Cats in the Courtyard - Coral's Story

By Patti Feuereisen (ed)

CORAL: **(Pg 74+)** My father took away my adolescence. It started in Greece, when I was ten, but the first time he raped me was after we moved to Holland, when I was twelve. From the ages of eleven to eighteen, I was abused by my father sexually on a regular basis . . . whenever he demanded it.

INTRODUCTION

Child sexual abuse has only recently been surfacing in Greece as an issue of concern among professionals, researchers and the public, following a long period of denial that continues to exist in many settings. However, it is important to realize that this type of abuse does occur world-wide and is not merely a US aberration. Regardless of the county, the long-term psychological impact on the young women who experience abuse, especially by their fathers, is undeniable.

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CORAL: My father is a professor. He is egocentric and has a major persecution complex, but he has cultivated a public image of being very intelligent and wise and calm. There was this aura around him, like he was a Zen monk or something.

At home he could not keep up the persona. At home he felt entitled to be moody, controlling, and belligerent. He ruled our house. His thoughts were the right thoughts, and my mother and I had to attend to his every mood and desire. What he said ruled.

My mother was a seamstress. She catered to his every whim. She took care of the house, cooked our meals, woke me up in the morning, and put me to bed. I remember getting a lot of love from her. Unlike my father, she was never smothering, telling me what I could and could not do, and she played with me a lot.

I have a lot of blank spots in my memories of my childhood. From what I have pieced together with the help of therapy, I know that when I was a child I was on my own a lot. I can remember one summer when I was six years old, my parents tied the house key to a

string and put it around my neck. I was to entertain myself during the day and return home by evening.

It has taken me years of therapy to realize that my mother was very afraid of life. She thought she'd found in my father a support system; with him she did not have to think on her own. My father mattered more to my mother than I did. She would rush around to get dinner on the table for him every night. She knew that if dinner was not on the table when he expected it, he would go on and on about how hungry he was and how he was a better cook anyway. I learned early on that what he ***said*** was not always what he ***meant***. He may have said we did not have to do certain things, but there was never really any choice.

The rule of our house was not to upset Daddy. He had an explosive temper, and at times he would throw fits, screaming and breaking things. My father was a master at manipulating reality. As long as we did what he wanted us to do, the household would run smoothly.

When I was very young, my father would leave for months at a time to attend university lectures in other countries, and my mother and I would bond. I would sleep in the big bed with her, which was a huge treat. When I climbed into her bed I felt very safe and cozy. We would play and eat when we wanted to, travel where and when we wanted to, and just relax.

When I was ten years old, my father started holding me just a little too long when he would hug me. I don't have any clear memory of being sexualized at ten, but things definitely got uncomfortable. He used to have me sit on his lap a lot. The first time he abused me sexually I was eleven. At least that's the first time I remember clearly. We were still living in Greece. I remember staring out the window at the garden downstairs when he came up behind me and touched my breasts under my shirt. I was wearing white summer pants and a little red top that I really loved. It had little bows on the side. I was wearing little white shoes with black dots. I even remember the underwear I was wearing.

I loved all animals, and I loved watching the cats in the courtyard as they played. As I stared at the cats, my father French-kissed me. My legs started shaking. I was supposed to go to a

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piano lesson, but he took me to his bed. I remember shaking all over and just focusing on the thought, "Soon I will be at my piano lesson." I don't remember exactly what he said to me, but I know he was telling me what he was doing would feel really good.

I was shaking the whole way to the piano lesson, and when I got there I couldn't play the music, I was shaking so much.

He raped me for the first time when I was twelve. We were living in Holland by then. My memories of it are like a sped-up film. He started to kiss me and I fought with him. I told him I did not like this; that I was a virgin and wanted to remain one. But he kept insisting that this was what I needed to do. He got angry. He screamed, "Enough of this!" and then stood up and pushed me and said, "Get naked and get in bed, now." I went into the bathroom and stayed there, then I got into my pajamas and got into **my** bed. He came and got me and put me in his bed, then climbed in, too. I was wearing my underwear and socks and three T-shirts under my pajamas; he was naked. I kept turning away from him and rolling onto my side.

I don't remember how one thing led to another, but at some point he took off my clothes, put a condom on, and began raping me. I was screaming and he covered my mouth. At that point I was present (I hadn't taught myself to leave my body yet), and I was in excruciating pain. Afterward he teased me and laughed at me and asked me why I was making such a fuss.

We hadn't been in Holland long, and I was having a hard enough time as it was. I did not speak English or Dutch. I had no family, no friends; my mother was traveling a lot; I had no protection or resources. My father could be so persuasive. He said that having sex with me was the natural way of things, and he cited all these examples of animals who are initiated into sex by their fathers. He babbled on about rituals and coming of age. He said that in the Jewish religion there is a ceremony call a bat mitzvah to celebrate the transition from child to woman and that he wanted to initiate me into womanhood.

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Thus began my father's invasion of my body and my soul. Any chance he got, he had intercourse with me. Because my life at home was a living hell, I built an fantasy world, and I had easy access to it. This world had elaborate characters with complicated story lines, in most I was a heroine saving abused orphans. In this other world, I was always strong and invincible. It seems I was always in that world when I was at home.

When I asked him why he was doing this to me, he said, "That's like putting a plate of spaghetti in front of a hungry man and asking him why he wants to eat it." It took me a long time to realize how much that line affected me. It must have been my fault; after all, I was the spaghetti. It must have been my fault I started to develop and was getting more attention from males.

He also said one thing that really got to me. He said that mothers know; they just do not discuss it with their daughters. He convinced me that my mother knew and was fine with it. When my mother would leave for her trips and say, "Take care of Daddy," I began to assume that this was some kind of secret code and she really ***did*** know what was happening. Everything felt really crazy and unsafe.

The one time I refused to comply, my mother was away on a five-day trip. I think I was fourteen at the time. I screamed, "No! I will not! Keep away from me!" and ran to my room and locked the door. There was a way to lock my door with a key from the outside, and my father actually locked me in my room and told me I had to stay in there without food or water until I came to my senses. I stayed in my room for at least a day and a half, until I felt faint and had to eat or drink something. Then I gave in and asked him to let me out.

Before I could even eat or shower, he raped me. After that experience, I figured it would be easier just to let it happen. I learned to leave my body and go somewhere else during the rapes. I'd go numb. I was always numb.

I used to think that my mother was not to blame. After all, I never told her about the abuse. But a memory that came back to me during therapy changed my view of her.

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When I was about fourteen, my father needed a photo of himself for a magazine cover and decided to have me stand naked in front of him. He would be dressed all in black, his eyes closed. He had my mother take the picture. You could not make out my face, but my body was clearly visible. The idea was that an artist can resist the temptation of the naked woman. Through my therapy I realized that my mother was really a co-conspirator.

My therapy has helped me to realize that I had no options during my childhood and adolescence and that the incest was not my fault. I now understand that my mother was weak and would not protect me. Also, there was no modesty allowed in my home. My parents walked around naked and expected me to do so as well. I was ridiculed by both of them if I expressed a desire to behave modestly. There was not even a door on the bathroom. When I was twelve years old and wanted a bathing suit top, my mother teased me and said that I was to continue to go topless at the beaches.

Even though I've been free of my parents for several years now, I still hear my father's voice inside my head controlling me at times. As the years move on, his voice is quieter and quieter. My therapist assures me that someday it will be so faint I will barely hear it.

Getting some perspective has helped me to begin to forgive myself. I still feel depressed at times. During my adolescence I developed severe headaches and frequent nausea, which I continue to suffer from. Some days I feel worthless. But I realize now that as a child and adolescent I did my best to keep myself alive. My mother was passive and frightened of the world. My father defined her every move. He molded her and tried to mold me, too. But with me he did not succeed.

At the time I was being molested, I thought I was the only one. If I could have read something at the time about sex abuse, if people had talked openly about it, I could have been saved so many years of guilt and shame and secrecy. Each time I talk about my incest, I get rid of some of that shame and guilt. Each person I share with, no matter what their response, takes another piece of the pain away.

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It's taken a while, but I have begun to see things through my own eyes. I have started to hear my own voice. Three years ago, I changed my name so I would no longer have to share a name with my father. I will never go back to Holland, and I will never go back to what my life was. I have choices and freedoms and I accept my incest as something that has happened to me. But it no longer defines who I am.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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